Though the offices of the leader of the House and the leader of the Opposition are not mentioned in the Constitution of India, they are mentioned in the Rules of the House and Parliamentary Statute respectively.

Whips

The office of 'whip' is mentioned neither in the Constitution of India nor in the Rules of the House. It is based on the conventions of the parliamentary government.

Every political party, whether ruling or opposition has its own Chief whip and whips in the Parliament. The whip is appointed by the political party to serve as an assistant floor leader. He/she is charged with the responsibility of ensuring the attendance of his/her party members in large numbers and securing their support in favour of or against a particular issue. He/she regulates and monitors their behaviour in the Parliament. The members are supposed to follow the directives given by the whip. Otherwise, disciplinary action can be taken.

The Chief whip of the government party in the Lok Sabha is the Minister of Parliamentary Affairs. In the Rajya Sabha, the Minister of State for Parliamentary Affairs holds this position. The Chief whip is directly responsible to the leader of the House. It is part of his/her duties to advise the government on parliamentary business and to maintain a close liaison with the ministers in regard to parliamentary business affecting their departments12a.

The Chief whip of a recognised party and a recognised group is entitled to telephone and secretarial facilities under the Leaders and Chief Whips of Recognised Parties and Groups in Parliament (Facilities) Act, 1998.

Under the above Act, a recognised party means every party which has a strength of not less than fifty-five members in respect of the Lok Sabha and twenty-five members in respect of the Rajya Sabha. Similarly, a recognised group means every party which has a strength of not less than thirty members in respect of the Lok Sabha and fifteen members in respect of the Rajya Sabha.

SESSIONS OF PARLIAMENT

Summoning

The President from time to time summons each House of Parliament to meet at such time and place as he/she thinks fit. But, the maximum gap between two sessions of Parliament cannot be more than six months. In other words, the Parliament should meet at least twice a year. There are usually three sessions in a year, viz,

1. The Budget Session (February to May);
2. The Monsoon Session (July to September); and
3. The Winter Session (November to December).

A 'session' of Parliament is the period spanning between the first sitting of a House and its prorogation (or dissolution in the case of the Lok Sabha). During a session, the House meets everyday to transact